



» WOMEN'S ODIs
INDIA-AUSTRALIA

TEST QUEENS GET HARSH WHITE-BALL REALITY CHECK

For India, there are still **plenty** of questions to answer before it hosts the ICC ODI World Cup in 2025.

Listless form: Harmanpreet Kaur's scores of 9, 5, and 3 in the three ODIs against Australia compounded India's woes. SPORTSPICS/BCCI

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India's fortnight of basking in red ball glory was bookended by two crucial and thought-provoking white ball series: the T20Is against Heather Knight's England and the ODIs against Alyssa Healy's Australia, with both ending in defeats.

These two results assume significance when one switches to the big picture, with two ICC tournaments coming up in 18 months, one in each format. However, that conversation took a back seat when India excelled emphatically in the longest format of the game, coming good with bat, ball, and on the field.

It's easy to see why the Indians like Tests. As Deepti Sharma put it during the one-off Test against England,

"The format allows the player time to stage a comeback should they lose their way slightly." The luxury of time is what India did not have in its 0-3 drubbing at the hands of Australia in the latter's favourite format, the ODIs, with notes aplenty for the host nation as it works towards building a framework for the home One-Day World Cup.

Litmus test for debutants

India entered the ODI series with four uncapped players: Saika Ishaque, Titas Sadhu, Shreyanka Patil, and Mannat Kashyap, of whom three got their maiden ODI caps. Shreyanka's impressive run in the England T20Is continued against the Aussies. In two ODIs, she claimed four wickets but stood out for her ability to improvise and control the line and length. Her 91-kmph yorker

to dismiss Ashleigh Gardner in the third ODI was particularly satisfying to watch. Despite being in the opposite dugout, this would have made her Royal Challengers Bangalore teammate, Ellyse Perry, proud.

Saika and Mannat did not encounter such luck, with Saika conceding 48 runs in the six overs she got in the first game and Mannat conceding 30 runs in the three overs in the third ODI. Both bowlers were lacklustre on the field too. Against this background, one feels bad for the one uncapped player who missed out—Titas. The Under-19 World Cup winner has easily had the most facetime with bowling coach Troy Cooley and is often there in the Indian nets from start to finish. India's policy to tilt its combination in